agreement in the Pacific rim, always with the USA at the centre of the project are, on the one hand, harsh blows against the globalism of the WTO and its partners and, on the other hand, a challenge for all the other nations that are not invited to participate in these gigantic trading and investment blocs.

This is a fairly messy situation consisting of (1) one nation-state as a unipolar superpower, (2) extensive free trade and investment areas where the most powerful agents are big private transnational corporations, (3) regional economic communities like the EU or the Mercosur and (4) new 'informal' state alliances entering the stage of global politics. BRICS is such an informal alliance without an elaborated formal institutional infrastructure. But as social science studies of informal labour clearly show, informality is not a static but a highly dynamic condition.

There are tendencies in the direction of further formalisation of the informal alliance, as well as other forces pointing in the opposite direction. The informality of the BRICS alliance is, so to say, a postmodern state of indecision in a global situation characterised by hard economic, financial, social and, above all, ecological constraints for political action. Hard planetary boundaries (Rockström et al. 2009) in the long run do not allow for soft arbitrariness.

A world in disorder

The tsunami of market liberalisation, of privatisation of public goods and services, of a wild deregulation of politics already began in the 1970s. It has proudly been called by Milton and Ruth Friedman (1980) 'the neoliberal counterrevolution'. It prepared the ground for the emerging new neoliberal world order which experienced, less than two decades later, a decisive political impulse from the fall of the Berlin Wall in 1989. Now the 'new' American century followed the 'old' one. The latter began at the end of World War II. It became determinant for global power relations for the next 40 years. It was the era of confrontation between the capitalist market economy ('the free West') and active socialism ('the authoritarian East'). The decisive difference between the old (before 1989) and the new (after 1989) American era was that the new, after the disappearance of active socialism, contained no place for a social system other than the market-capitalist one. The 'short 20th century' (Eric Hobsbawm 1995) ended without the perspective of an alternative system in the cul-de-sac of a history with a past and a present, but without a future. The socialist world (in the East) since then turned from the present and the future into a past history, as did the 'Socialism of the West', the Keynesian interventionism of the nation-states, and the 'Socialism of the South', i.e. of the development state which had its origin in Latin America.